

Gaming networks

The internet has made it possible for people to play games with each other regardless of where they are in the world. Dedicated gaming networks also allow users to buy games, upload videos of them playing, and share achievements.

Steam

Steam is a digital storefront that sells games, and also allows players to play those games online on Windows, Mac, and Linux operating systems. It started in 2003 with seven games, but currently has tens of thousands of titles.

PlayStation Network

With 110 million members worldwide, PlayStation Network is the largest gaming platform. It is designed to allow players of Sony's PlayStation consoles to interact with each other over games, films, and music.

Xbox Live

Designed to run on Microsoft's Xbox console range, Xbox Live allows users to play games with each other online, and use an array of apps, including video-streaming, sport, music, and video chat.

Advantages of playing games online

Gaming online can be thought of as being a social network centred around the activity of playing games. On the big online gaming networks, gamers can create an avatar and make friends. Some networks and games limit the ability for players to interact with each other, especially if the players are likely to be young.



Making friends

Playing games and socializing with new people online is a way of making friends and developing social skills, and even learning about different countries and cultures.



Keeping friends

A great way of staying in touch with friends – particularly friends who do not live in the same area – is by having shared experiences. Online gaming can be one of these.



Having fun and relaxing

It can be a very enjoyable experience to step inside the new worlds that gaming offers. In moderation, gaming can help reduce stress and improve cognitive function.

Online hate

Gaming networks are no different from other kinds of social networks when it comes to negativity and abuse. Users can even face aggressive or threatening behaviour at times. Thankfully, gaming network providers advise gamers to report abusive players, and take action on receiving these reports.

▷ Trolls

A troll is someone who communicates in a deliberately offensive or provocative way online. A troll may try to anger other players by being loud, aggressive, or destructive.



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Gaming terms

FPS: First-person shooter.

Griefing: When an online player intentionally causes irritation or anger to other players when playing a game together.

MMORPG: Massively multiplayer online role-playing game: a game where a player creates a character and can interact with large numbers of other players in an online world.

Rage quitting: When someone gets so angry that they quit their game.

RPG: Role-playing game: a game where the player either makes or becomes a character and usually interacts with a fantastical environment.